his statue of a seated, contemplative Gandhi for Parliament House is considered his most distinguished creation.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had pushed for the colossal Patel project from the days he was chief minister of Gujarat. He laid its foundation on October 31, 2013. After Modi's landslide victory, its creation became a certainty.

Decades earlier, Sutar had caught the eye of Jawaharlal Nehru when he was employed by the Archaeological Survey of India to restore the Ellora sculptures. After his 45-ft concrete statue of the Chambal river personified as a beautiful maiden with her two sons—Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan—clinging to her was unveiled, Nehru was much impressed. He commissioned Sutar to create a 50-ft bronze monument dedicated to the workers who laid down their lives to construct the Bhakra Nangal Dam. The theme of the statue was to be the 'Triumph of Labour', but it was shelved owing to paucity of funds.

Sutar was a favourite of Mayawati. As a Dalit CM of Uttar Pradesh, she stipulated an impossible "auspicious" deadline when she commissioned Sutar to create a statue of B.R. Ambedkar. On completion, Mayawati demanded the statue be installed forthwith despite torrential downpours. Finally, when the gruelling exercise was over at an ungodly 11.30 pm, Mayawati happily garlanded it. How many sculptors would put up with such whimsicality?

Neither would many artists be willing to quote the lowest figures when a government tender is floated. If Sutar is to be believed, only once—while working on a Gandhi statue when Morarji Desai was PM—did he have to face the humiliation of bidding for two tenders for a single project, one for creating the clay statue, the other for casting it. Usually, both are done by the same sculptor for consistent quality.

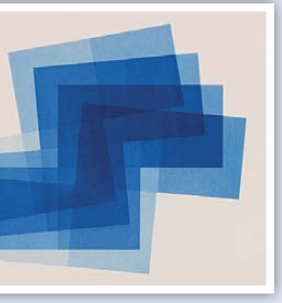
The simple and unassuming Sutar has survived because he has navigated through the murky waters of politics, yet managed to keep his own hands clean. In his six-decade-long career, he is India's best known "sarkari" sculptor. He has been the favourite of almost every government at the Centre. Born in February 1925 at Gondur, Dhule, Maharashtra, Sutar arrived in Delhi in 1959, after landing a modeller's job with the Directorate of Audio Visual Publicity. He was born into a poor family belonging to the Vishwakarma community of traditional artisans. With the help of Shriram Krishna Joshi, a drawing teacher at the teachers' training college in Dhule, he graduated from Mumbai's Sir JJ School of Art with the Mayo gold medal in 1952.

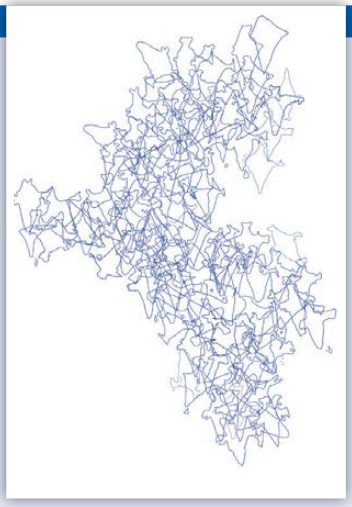
When Bandeep Singh, INDIA TODAY's Group Photo Editor, went for a shoot to Sutar's studio, he was surprised at the "agility" of this nonagenarian who preferred to stand rather than sit. Singh was also struck by his "unflinching gaze...as if he was seeing into things". In the vast halls of the studio, "gods jostled for space with political leaders. Atal Bihari Vajpayee stood next to Hanuman. Saraswati stood next to Indira Gandhi. The statues were at different stages of completion. Limbs scattered all around looked surrealistic. It was like simultaneous creation and destruction," says Singh.

Ram Sutar's countless statues, life-like—based as they are mostly on photographs—may be conventional, but they have the virtue of being instantly recognisable. A West Bengal minister had in 1984 expressed his disapproval of Ramkinkar Baij's statue of Rabindranath Tagore because it "did not look like" the poet. No one can make such an accusation against Ram Sutar. Replication is his speciality. ■

Soumitra Das







THE DEEPEST COLOUR
(Clockwise from top left) Works by Prajakta Potnis, Anju Dodiya, Shilpa Gupta and Parul Gupta, showcased at the *Prussian Blue* exhibition

populations. Bihari artists Subodh Gupta and Shambhavi have both created nostalgia-laden works that link Prussian blue to a feeling of homecoming, or of pining for the simple, pastoral life of their homeland.

According to curator Arshiya Lokhandwala, "One of the starting points for the exhibition was my late father. He had a paint factory and Prussian blue was his favourite. Almost all of the artists included here met him and knew him and I think that adds a personal touch to the show. You can't create an elaborate, detailed show like this without love, without having a deeply personal connection with the theme." Lokhandwala's father also had another connection to the pigment—he studied in Germany as well and, later, because of his factory, realised the artistic as well as commercial value of Prussian blue (the pigment was sturdy, affordable and had superb tinting ability). "If you see the German artist Alke Reeh's work in the show," says Lokhandwala, "it's called 'Sewed Ceiling' (textile and Prussian blue pigments) and it's a beautiful expression of what the colour means to the artist. She has linked it to the symbolism of the sky and of various world mythologies."

Prussian Blue is one of those instantly agreeable exhibitions that have something of obvious value for everyone, regardless of age or taste or artistic leaning. ■

Aditya Mani Jha